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Seminar:

**The Portrayal of Immigrants and Their Integration into American and Israeli Society as
Part of the National Family: *Modern Family* and *Nevsu***

All In The Family: An Intercultural Perspective Of Israeli and American Television

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The Portrayal of Immigrants and Their Integration into American and Israeli Society as Part of the National Family: *Modern Family* and *Nevsu*

Introduction

In recent decades, family sitcoms have evolved to include a broader range of voices and experiences, serving as both a mirror and a mold for cultural values regarding family, gender, and societal integration. The television shows *Modern Family* (2009- 2020) in the United States and *Nevsu* (2017-2021) in Israel stand out in this genre for their portrayals of immigrant women, Gloria and Almito, respectively, who must navigate and integrate into societies markedly different from the country they were born and raised in. Through humor, both shows shed light on immigrant experiences, challenging societal assumptions around ethnicity, race, and family integration. This paper examines the role of these two sitcoms in portraying immigrant identities within their respective national (Israeli and American) families, investigating how each character, as a foreign-born mother, embodies the hopes, struggles, and cultural expectations of immigrants in American and Israeli societies.

The United States and Israel are societies that are heavily shaped by diverse immigration histories such as Ellis Island in America or Operation Magic Carpet in Israel. Sitcoms have long served as cultural constructs, presenting ideals and reflecting tensions in family and national identity. Gloria from *Modern Family* and Almito from *Nevsu* each bring their own cultural backgrounds, personal narratives, and mothering styles, which are filtered through the comedic storytelling of their respective shows. Their roles as immigrant mothers place them at the intersection of gender and ethnic identities, compelling audiences to consider how each society's view of the immigrant experience influences these characters' portrayals.

In this seminar, I aim to answer the question: How do the sitcoms *Modern Family* and *Nevsu* portray and represent the experiences of immigrant characters, particularly in relation to inter-gender, inter-ethnic, and interracial dynamics within patriarchal family structures? Through

examining the characters' journeys and interactions, this paper will analyze the ways these sitcoms address social values, cultural integration, and the portrayal of immigrant family members within traditional family units.

The following sections will provide a historical context for each show, comparing the United States and Israeli immigration landscapes and the societal dynamics around race, ethnicity, and family representation. By examining the portrayal of Gloria and Almito, I will explore how both shows reflect societal attitudes towards immigrants and discuss the implications of these portrayals for broader national conversations on family and identity. Through this comparative analysis, I will argue that while both shows address themes of family and integration, their approaches reflect the unique societal concerns of their production environments, contributing to a broader understanding of the immigrant experience as part of each nation's evolving identity.

Immigration and Racial Dynamics in Television

Television has historically played a powerful role in reflecting and shaping societal norms, with family sitcoms serving as a medium for depicting social values and addressing contentious topics in a relatable manner. In both the United States and Israel, family sitcoms like *Modern Family* and *Nevsu* use humor and the familiar structure of family life to address themes of immigration, race, and inter-ethnic relationships. To understand how each show approaches these themes, it is essential to explore the historical and sociopolitical contexts of immigration and racial dynamics in the United States and Israel, focusing on how these contexts influence societal perspectives on immigrants and inter-ethnic family units through television.

Since the mid-20th century, American sitcoms have reflected and commented on societal change, often engaging with issues of race and ethnicity. One of the earliest groundbreaking examples is *I Love Lucy* (1951–1957), which depicted a Cuban-American husband, Ricky Ricardo, alongside his American wife, Lucy. This portrayal of an inter-ethnic relationship was revolutionary for its time, challenging a social and media landscape that rarely included such dynamics. However, as Mary Desjardins observes in "Lucy and Desi: Sexuality, Ethnicity, and TV's First Family," *I Love Lucy* carried inherent contradictions in its portrayal of ethnicity and gender within 1950s patriarchal culture. While Ricky Ricardo was presented as a devoted husband and entertainer, his character was often infantilized or rendered as an outsider due to his Cuban heritage, accent, and passionate outbursts (Desjardins 57).

Desjardins highlights how the show balanced these cultural tensions by juxtaposing the "reel" lives of Lucy and Ricky Ricardo with the "real" lives of Lucille Ball and Desi Arnaz, the actors playing the main couple in *I Love Lucy*. The Arnazes' off-screen marriage and business partnership served as a counterpoint to the sitcom's depiction of Ricky's volatility and Lucy's comedic antics. Despite these complexities, *I Love Lucy* ultimately reinforced the cultural norms of its time by centering the patriarchal nuclear family and promoting domestic harmony as the ideal. (Desjardins 58)

Similarly, as Charles Ramírez Berg argues in “Latino Images in Film: Stereotypes, Subversion, and Resistance,” Latino characters in U.S. media were often confined to reductive stereotypes such as the “male buffoon” or the “Latin lover.” Ricky Ricardo, while a more nuanced character, still embodied traits that aligned with the stereotype of the male buffoon: a heavy accent, emotional outbursts, and a sense of comedic inferiority compared to Lucy’s scheming ingenuity (Ramírez Berg 71). These portrayals reinforced cultural hierarchies, casting Latino characters as deviations from the Anglo-American norm while failing to grant them the same narrative agency as their white counterparts.

What is funny about this character, what the audiences are given to laugh at are the very characteristics that separate him from Hollywood's vision of the WASP American mainstream. For example, [the male buffoon] is simpleminded, he cannot master standard English [Such as Ricky's "Lucy, you got some'splainin'to do!"]], and he childishly regresses into emotionality [For Example, Ricky's verbal explosions into Spanish]. (Ramírez Berg 71-72)

As television evolved, sitcoms began to challenge these conventions. Shows like *Modern Family* represent a shift toward more nuanced portrayals of Latino characters, as seen in Gloria Pritchett. Gloria’s character both engages with and disrupts these historical stereotypes. While she embodies some traits associated with Latina stereotypes—such as her fiery personality and accent—she also challenges them by occupying a central, respected role in the family. As Mora argues in “Reading a Complex Latina Stereotype,” Gloria’s portrayal complicates traditional stereotypes, presenting her as a multidimensional character who navigates intersecting identities of race, gender, and class. This evolution reflects broader societal changes in the United States, where media increasingly sought to represent diversity and multiculturalism while grappling with the persistence of stereotypical portrayals. (Mora 148)

“The social identities encompassing Gloria Pritchett are taken apart and compounded, which in turn, suggest that her intersectionality was malleable for viewers.” (Mora 133)

The United States has historically been shaped by waves of immigration, each contributing to the nation's evolving identity while introducing tensions around assimilation and inclusion. This dynamic is vividly portrayed in *Modern Family*, where Gloria Pritchett's character reflects both the ideals and challenges of a multicultural America. As a Colombian immigrant, Gloria's integration into the Pritchett family embodies the potential for cultural enrichment and the blending of identities. At the same time, her portrayal exposes lingering biases and stereotypes that continue to shape perceptions of immigrants in the United States.

As Richard Butsch notes, domestic sitcoms, like *Father Knows Best* (1954–1960), presented idealized, middle-class nuclear families with clearly defined roles and little acknowledgment of racial or cultural diversity. This trend began to shift in the 1970s with shows like *All in the Family* (1971–1979), which tackled social issues such as racism and class conflict but often did so by framing lower-status groups through humor and stereotypes (Butsch 119-121).

Modern Family builds on this legacy, representing a more inclusive vision of family that reflects 21st-century attitudes toward race and cultural integration. Gloria's presence in the Pritchett family expands the traditional sitcom framework, signaling a move toward inclusivity. Unlike earlier portrayals that relegated immigrant characters to peripheral or comedic roles, Gloria occupies a central, respected position as a wife, mother, and stepmother. Yet, as Butsch observes, sitcoms often use humor to underscore cultural differences, and Gloria is no exception. Her fiery personality, thick accent, and frequent references to Colombian traditions serve as sources of comedic tension, reinforcing certain stereotypes even as her character challenges others.

For example, in the episode, "Queer Eyes, Full Hearts," Gloria feels misunderstood by her husband, Jay, after he allowed her son Manny to enroll in French class and drop out of Spanish. Jay allowed this because he was jealous of Manny's younger, Spanish-speaking tutor. Gloria yells at him out of frustration: "Do you know how frustrating it is to have to translate everything in my head before I say it? To have people laugh in my face because I'm struggling to find the words?" After saying this, Jay still corrects her English to which she responds: "Do you even

know how smart I am in Spanish? Of course you don't. For once it would be nice to speak in my own language in my own home.”

Lynn Spigel's analysis of postwar television highlights its dual role as a domestic and cultural force, shaping ideas of family unity while reinforcing societal norms. In *Modern Family*, Gloria's character reflects this tension. Television, Spigel argues, has historically been a space where notions of harmony and discord coexist, mirroring broader societal anxieties about identity and belonging (Spigel 74). Gloria's Colombian heritage and her efforts to maintain her cultural identity while integrating into an American family highlight these contradictions. Her traditions are both celebrated as enriching the family dynamic and othered as points of comedic misunderstanding. Spigel's work also emphasizes the importance of the “domestic space” as a site where societal values are negotiated and reflected.

“Family members in domestic space were divided along sexual and social lines. Here, the ideal of family togetherness was achieved through the seemingly contradictory principle of separation; [...] The social division of space was not simply the inverse of family unity; rather, it was a point on a continuum which stressed ideals of domestic cohesion.

[Through] developing a room which is 'entirely public' ... privacy is made possible.”

(Spigel 90)

The sitcom format, with its emphasis on family life, becomes a platform for exploring the complexities of multicultural integration. Gloria's character serves as a reminder of the challenges immigrants face in balancing cultural preservation with the pressures of assimilation. At the same time, her central role in the Pritchett family illustrates the potential for cross-cultural understanding within a modern, diverse household. The recurring use of stereotypes in sitcoms often reflects broader cultural hierarchies, with marginalized groups depicted in ways that reinforce their lower status. However, Gloria's portrayal complicates this pattern. While elements of her characterization align with traditional Latina stereotypes, her position as a central, empowered figure within the family marks a significant departure from the peripheral roles often

assigned to immigrant characters in earlier sitcoms. At the end of the episode, “Queer Eyes, Full Hearts,” Jay rehires the Spanish tutor for himself so he can learn Spanish for Gloria. He tells her he is sorry in Spanish to which she happily exclaims, “Now you sound like the stupid one!”

Israeli television has similarly used sitcoms as a platform for exploring cultural and racial dynamics, but the context is shaped by Israel’s unique history of immigration and integration. Early Israeli sitcoms, such as *Krovim Krovim* (1983-1986), were modeled on American formats but adapted to reflect Israeli culture and identity. As Sharon Shahaf explains in “Welcome to the Sitcom School: A Globalized Outlook”, *Krovim Krovim* was one of the first Israeli sitcoms to portray an “authentic” Israeli family, addressing the realities of Israeli life in a period when media was increasingly influenced by global television trends. Despite adopting a familiar sitcom format, these shows were distinctively Israeli, reflecting the nation’s focus on collective identity, integration, and cultural preservation. (Shahaf 104)

Nevsu is a recent example of an Israeli sitcom that tackles themes of racial and cultural integration within an immigrant family. The show centers on Gili, an Ethiopian immigrant married to an Israeli woman of Ashkenazi descent, Tamar. Gili’s character draws attention to the unique challenges faced by Ethiopian immigrants, who have historically struggled with economic and social marginalization in Israel. Almito (played by Meskie Shibru-Sivan) is Gili and his siblings’ mother who she raised in a Jewish-Ethiopian village until they were able to immigrate to Israel when Gili was a child. Similar to Gloria in *Modern Family*, Almito and her family face stereotyping but are largely accepted by their Ashkenazi in-law’s family. Almito and Gili encounter slightly more direct challenges related to their ethnic and cultural identity, reflecting the complexities of Israel’s multi-ethnic society. For example, the opening scene of *Nevsu* is Gili getting stopped by a police officer outside his own house after getting water from his car. He is only saved because his white, Ashkenazi wife, Tamar, shames the police and gets Gili released. In the same episode, we are introduced to Almito, Gili’s mother, speaking with her brother in Amharic after he arrives at her door with a goat to sacrifice for her husband’s memorial. The

exterior shots of Almito's neighborhood before her scene set up that she is living in a predominantly Ethiopian neighborhood, unlike those of Gili and Tamar's Parents which feature suburban moshav exterior shots.

The Ethiopian Jewish community's journey to Israel was fraught with hardship that continued after they arrived to their homeland. As Shula Mola discusses in "Ethiopian Immigrants and the Perception of Media," Ethiopian Jews were granted immigration rights under Israel's Law of Return, but their integration into Israeli society has been difficult, marred by discrimination and socio-economic disparities (Mola 71-72).

Israel's history of immigration is distinctively tied to its national identity as a Jewish state, which aims to unite the global Jewish diaspora. Yet, as Sylvie Fogiel-Bijaoui notes in "A Rising Tide? Mixed Families in Israel", interracial and inter-ethnic families, such as Gili's, are seen as challenging traditional definitions of Jewish identity and societal homogeneity. . (Fogiel-Bijaoui 109)

Generally speaking, [art and media] tend to challenge negative constructions of mixed families and to depict mixed intimacies as legitimate and as part and parcel of the ongoing global societal transformation. (Fogiel-Bijaoui 109)

Gili's family life and interactions with his wife's relatives thus encapsulate the cultural tensions in Israel around ethnicity, race, and family. By situating his character within an Ashkenazi family, *Nevsu* highlights the implicit expectations placed on Ethiopian immigrants to assimilate into mainstream Israeli culture while looked at as an "other", raising questions about the limits of inclusion and the persistence of cultural hierarchy. For example, in Episode 6 of *Nevsu*, Gili's Ashkenazi mother-in-law, Nitza, is worried that Maayan (Gili's daughter) will grow up and have an Ethiopian accent like Gili and Almito and secretly attempts to secretly "fix" Maayan's accent

by taking her to speech correction classes behind the back of the family. When Almito finds out that Nitza doesn't like her or her family's accent she is hurt.

Analysis of Characters: Gloria (*Modern Family*) and Almito (*Nevsu*)

In *Modern Family* and *Nevsu*, the characters of Gloria and Almito bring women immigrant perspectives into traditional family structures, representing two distinct immigrant experiences in the United States and Israel. Through these characters, each show reveals underlying cultural attitudes towards immigrants and examines the ways in which immigrant identity, gender, and family dynamics intersect. Both women navigate family life as mothers and family members yet their experiences highlight the contrasting ways that American and Israeli societies view integration, and cultural identity within familial and societal expectations. This section explores their roles as immigrant mothers, as well as how they are treated by other characters, to understand each society's portrayal of immigrant identity and the intersections of race, ethnicity, and gender.

In *Modern Family*, Gloria Pritchett is a Colombian immigrant who marries Jay, a wealthy, older American man, bringing her son Manny into Jay's affluent American family. Gloria's character, played by Sofia Vergara, is portrayed with as a loving housewife making her both an insider and outsider within her new family. While Gloria's Latina identity is integral to her character, her immigrant background is often played for humor, positioning her as both exotic and unfamiliar within the context of her American family. Her strong accent, fiery personality, and proud embrace of Colombian traditions offer a contrast to Jay's reserved and distinctly American demeanor, creating comedic tension and cultural misunderstandings that are central to her character's interactions. Gloria's maternal role is deeply tied to her cultural background, with her son, Manny, embodying both Colombian and American identities. Gloria's character conveys the importance of cultural assimilation pressures, allowing her to assert her identity while also adapting to life within an American family.

Almito, in *Nevsu*, also portrays a mother navigating the challenges of cultural integration and family life. Her family and children are Ethiopian but similarly to Gloria's son, they embody a more stereotypical Israeli side in contrast with their mother. Her son Gil marrying into a family

with Ashkenazi descent, causes Almito's character to face further familial obstacles that reflect the difficulties Ethiopian immigrants may encounter in Israel. Unlike Gloria, whose cultural differences are humorously celebrated, Almito's Ethiopian identity often becomes a source of humorous conflict, reflecting the complexities of racial and cultural acceptance in Israeli society. Her interactions with her in-laws highlight the expectation for her to assimilate into the Israeli culture while downplaying her Ethiopian heritage.

Almito's character confronts issues specific to Ethiopian immigrants in Israel, who, as Orly Kayam notes, often face marginalization and discrimination due to their racial and cultural backgrounds in their day to day lives and in their media representation (Kayam 4). Almito's role as a mother, especially within the context of her mixed family, places her in a unique position where she must balance her Ethiopian heritage with the Israeli cultural norms expected by her son's family and her younger, more "integrated" children. This balancing act reflects the broader societal pressure for Ethiopian immigrants to integrate and conform to the Israeli cultural standards that dominate Israeli society. Through Almito's character, *Nevsu* reveals the complexities of immigrant integration in Israel.

Within *Modern Family*, Gloria is often the subject of both admiration and mild amusement due to her Colombian background, which is treated as both a defining and humorous aspect of her identity. Jay's family members, particularly Jay himself, frequently express surprise or confusion at her customs, accent, and cultural expressions. While this treatment is usually benign, it reflects an American fascination with "exotic" immigrant cultures that is both curious and stereotypical.

Gloria Pritchett is subsequently Otherized in *Modern Family* at the expense of her gendered Latinidad. Her combined gender and ethnic Otherness comes from a pronounced sexuality and immigrant status that in turn establish her as different and exotic among other cultural markers that fall outside middleclassness like her attire and language. Being different from others in a situational comedy, she is the perfect candidate for comedic racial microaggressions that ultimately marginalize the character in subtle ways. On one

occasion, for instance, Jay Pritchett's first wife publicly disclosed (while drunk) the reasons for their unbelievable marriage: her corporal advantage and his economic cache. (Mora 6)

The subtle yet persistent stereotypes Gloria faces in *Modern Family* reflect broader societal attitudes in the U.S., where immigrant identities are frequently celebrated but also confined to simplified narratives. Gloria's character illustrates the intersection of ethnicity, gender, and language as comedic devices. Gloria's heavily accented English and grammatical errors serve as markers of her racialized identity, contributing to her portrayal as an authentic but stereotypical Latina immigrant (Casillas 69). This linguistic portrayal reinforces social hierarchies within the show, as Gloria's speech is often corrected by other characters, particularly Jay, whose Standard American English aligns with societal expectations of linguistic superiority

Listeners perceive accents as markers of a speaker's "good" or "bad" English, equating a "good" command of English with SAE notions of whiteness and "bad" English with racialized forms of speech by communities of color and immigrants. [Language racializes one's identity, making Spanish speakers feel] surveilled when speaking either English or Spanish. US Latinos often struggle with being unfairly framed as inarticulate in both English and Spanish (Casillas 70).

Throughout the show, many jokes that involve Gloria throughout the show laugh at Gloria's accent. This dynamic subtly positions Gloria's accented English as inferior and humorous, a strategy that underscores Jay's dominance while marginalizing Gloria's cultural identity. Casillas and colleagues argue that this linguistic "gatekeeping" not only reflects but also perpetuates real-world attitudes toward accented speakers, aligning Standard American English with whiteness and cultural capital (Casillas 74-75).

In *Nevsu*, Almito faces more direct and overt scrutiny from her son's Israeli-born (Sabre) Ashkenazi family, who often express discomfort or confusion over her Ethiopian background. In

the first episode of *Nevsu*, Almito plans to slaughter a goat for her husband's upcoming memorial. This is a Jewish Ethiopian custom during memorials and is an important tradition to Almito. Her daughter in law, Tamar, sees things differently and believes that if her daughter, Maayan, is close to this "sacrifice" it could be traumatic for her. This treatment highlights the challenges Ethiopian immigrants in Israel face as they attempt to integrate into a society that views them as culturally and racially distinct from the Jewish mainstream. The interactions between Almito and her in-laws are often characterized by misunderstandings or subtle prejudice such as this, reflecting the Israeli cultural expectations placed on immigrants to assimilate. By the end of the episode, Almito agrees not to sacrifice the goat and instead keeps it in her apartment for Maayan to play with. Instead, she serves her guests bourkas as is common in Israeli- Ashkenazi memorials. Unlike Gloria, whose differences are usually treated as humorous quirks, Almito's differences are often seen as points of contention.

Almito's character brings this marginalization into the spotlight, as her interactions reveal the implicit bias that exists within Israeli society toward Ethiopian immigrants. The show portrays Almito as a caring mother and represents the Ethiopian family as one that is close and loving. As Nir Wolff describes in his article about *Nevsu*:

From the point of view of the Ethiopian community, "Nevsu" is of enormous importance due to the fact that it is a popular series on a commercial channel, which spans cultural gaps, examines the difficulties of absorption and acceptance and shows the opacity and arrogance of the establishment society and the absurdity of racism. If you like, "Nevsu" is to the Ethiopians what "Salah Shabbati" was to the Mizrahim. (Wolff 2020)

Almito's portrayal in *Nevsu* reveals the complexities of immigrant integration in Israel, particularly for Ethiopian Jews, who face unique racial and cultural challenges. As Jamal notes, Israeli media often encode a hegemonic model of "Israeliness" that marginalizes minorities by requiring them to conform to Ashkenazi cultural norms (Jamal 1353). This dynamic is evident in

Almito's interactions with her Ashkenazi in-laws, where her Ethiopian traditions, such as the planned goat sacrifice in Episode 1, are met with skepticism and discomfort.

Unlike Gloria, whose cultural differences are often treated humorously, Almito's Ethiopian heritage becomes a source of conflict, highlighting the more overt racial and cultural biases in Israeli society. As Jamal argues, the hegemonic model of cultural assimilation in Israeli media often excludes or disciplines minority participants, framing their traditions as incompatible with mainstream norms (Jamal 1351- 1352) Almito's decision to compromise, keeping the goat as a pet instead of sacrificing it, reflects the societal pressure to adapt while preserving her cultural identity within the family.

Participants coming from minority groups must meet certain prerequisites and adopt behaviour codes which inevitably challenge their own particularistic identity. They are required to make adjustments and modifications in their own culture, language, customs, beliefs and values in order to be admitted to that exclusive club called *Israeliness*. (Jamal 1352)

Differences and Similarities in the Portrayal of Immigration

Through the characters of Gloria and Almito, *Modern Family* and *Nevsu* offer two approaches to depicting immigrant experiences within family structures in the United States and Israel. These portrayals reflect the societal values, historical contexts, and cultural attitudes towards immigration in each country. While both shows address themes of family, identity, and integration, they differ in how they situate their immigrant characters within their respective family dynamics and societal expectations. This section compares the centrality of Gloria and Almito within their family structures, the cultural tensions they navigate, and how each show's portrayal of immigration reflects broader themes in American and Israeli societies.

In *Modern Family*, Gloria's role as Jay's wife and Manny's mother places her at the core of the Pritchett family, a position that allows her to influence the family's dynamics and contribute to its evolving identity. Gloria's presence within the family introduces a multicultural dimension that enriches the family's experience, yet her Colombian identity is not perceived as a barrier to her full integration. Instead, her differences are generally embraced as part of the "modern" family's diversity. *Modern Family* uses Gloria's role to explore themes of acceptance and multiculturalism, suggesting that American identity can be fluid and inclusive, shaped by diverse influences without being fundamentally challenged. In the episode "The Kiss," Gloria is in the kitchen cooking a traditional Colombian recipe, Chunchullo. Gloria explains that she has been having dreams where her grandmother is telling her she is losing touch with her Colombian roots. Jay tells Gloria it smells good until Manny tells him that what she is making contains pig intestines. He then begs Gloria to eat "normal food." Gloria, upset with Jay, asks him to apologize for making fun of her culture. He continues to poke fun until Gloria decides to mess with him. Gloria tricks Jay into performing bogus traditions that she made up, such as slapping and yelling at chicken or walking around with shoes around his neck. Finally, Gloria tells Jay that he needs to be more loving and accepting, not only of her but of the entire family. The episode ultimately

celebrates with the extended family enjoying the traditional Chunchullo and raising a toast to Gloria's abuela.

Through Gloria, *Modern Family* portrays a relatively seamless integration of an immigrant character into the family, emphasizing individualism and self-expression. Gloria's ability to maintain her cultural heritage while becoming a full member of the Pritchett family reflects American values of pluralism and self-identity.

In contrast, Almito's role in *Nevsu* is characterized by her struggle for acceptance within her family. Her Ethiopian background often positions her as an outsider within her own extended and even immediate family, where her cultural identity becomes a point of tension rather than celebration. Although Almito is a central character in the show, her experiences highlight the difficulties that Ethiopian immigrants may face in gaining full acceptance in Israeli society, where cultural integration is often expected to conform to Ashkenazi/Sabre norms. Her identity as an Ethiopian immigrant is seen as challenging the family's coherence rather than adding to it, reflecting the societal pressures on Ethiopian Israelis to assimilate rather than maintain their distinct cultural identity.

Almito is mother to Gili but also two younger teenagers- Ortal and Eliran. In episode 2, Almito sees Ortal in the street with her friend and when she tries to greet them, Ortal and her friend ignore Almito and run away. Almito is hurt by this and believes Ortal is ashamed of her. When she goes to Gili and Tamar for advice, they tell her that all teenagers are ashamed of their mothers.

However, Tamar's mother (Nitza) gives her own unsolicited advice: "What is bothering Ortal? Let's start with how you dress, you know. Almito'le, it wouldn't hurt you to go with me to shop at the mall. You should distinguish between where you buy vegetables and where you buy clothes." Nitza continues, "It's graceful how you mix Amharic and Hebrew and Gibberish but to a sixteen year old girl it's terrible. She doesn't want her mother to stand out, she wants her to disappear."

The rest of the episode, Almito tries to learn how to speak in "cool" Hebrew from her son, Eliran.

This portrayal reflects the collective nature of Israeli society, where identity is often tied to a shared national or religious heritage. As Sylvie Fogiel-Bijaoui discusses in “A Rising Tide? Mixed Families in Israel,” mixed families in Israel, especially those involving Ethiopian immigrants, can face significant pressure to conform to the dominant cultural norms, creating a less flexible environment for immigrant integration (Fogiel-Bijaoui 108). Almito’s position within her family underscores the limitations placed on Ethiopian Israelis’ cultural expression, suggesting that full inclusion in Israeli society may require a degree of cultural erasure or adaptation to Israeli standards.

In *Modern Family*, Gloria’s Colombian heritage often introduces humorous misunderstandings and cultural differences that the family navigates without significant conflict. In the episode “Lake Life,” the extended family take a trip on a houseboat at a large lake. Gloria says she doesn’t trust lakes, saying where she comes from, this is where we dump the drugs and dead bodies. Cam, Jay’s son-in-law, wants to show Gloria the beauty of the lake and sails her around on a small boat. Gloria, still suspicious of the lake, sees what she believes is a duffle bag floating in the water. Cam replies, “It’s just a Buoy.” Horrified, Gloria screams: “A boy!?”

Her cultural identity becomes a source of warmth and affection, with her family, particularly Jay, learning to appreciate and even adopt aspects of her Colombian background. This dynamic reflects an American societal expectation that immigrants can enrich the culture without significantly challenging its foundations. Gloria’s character allows *Modern Family* to address topics of immigration and cultural difference while maintaining a lighthearted, family-centered narrative.

This portrayal aligns with the American “melting pot” ideal, where cultural differences are valued but ultimately absorbed into a broader national identity. As Lynn Spiegel discusses in “Television in the Family Circle: The Popular Reception of a New Medium,” American television has historically used the family sitcom to both reflect and shape societal values, often presenting diversity as a source of enrichment rather than conflict.

In its capacity as a unifying agent, television fit well with the more general postwar hopes for a return to domestic values. It was seen as a kind of household cement which promised to reassemble the splintered lives of families who had been separated during the war. It was also meant to reinforce the new suburban family unit which had left most of its extended family behind in the city. (Spiegel 76)

Gloria's portrayal suggests that America's cultural landscape can accommodate diversity through shared family values and mutual respect, embodying the American ideal of a unified yet diverse society.

In *Nevsu*, cultural differences between Almito and her son, Gili's, family are not merely sources of humor but become focal points for exploring the challenges of assimilation. Almito's Ethiopian background often places her at odds with the family's expectations, as her customs, language, and appearance contrast sharply with Ashkenazi cultural norms. Unlike Gloria, whose identity is often celebrated, Almito's Ethiopian heritage becomes a barrier that she must navigate carefully, reflecting Israel's more rigid approach to cultural integration and its expectation for immigrants to conform to mainstream standards. During episode 11 of *Nevsu*, we discover that Almito is working as a hospital janitor and that to fit in she is going by the name "Agam," a very typical Israeli name. When Gili finds out about this he is confused at his mother's behavior. She explains to Gili that it is hard for white people to say 'Almito' so she changed her name. "Gili, since I became Agam, everything opened up for me! Professors speak to me who didn't acknowledge me before." Gili tells her that he finds it ridiculous to which Almito replies: "And Gili isn't? I want to remind you that you were born in Nigosa Chalacho! Let's see you survive one day in an office with a name like that."

This portrayal underscores how Israeli society navigates tensions between collective identity and multicultural integration. Almito's Ethiopian heritage in *Nevsu* brings to light societal expectations for assimilation within a dominant cultural framework. Drawing on Israel's historical emphasis on national unity, which has roots in its early nation-building ethos and the 'melting pot'

policy for Jewish immigrants, the series critiques the rigidity of this approach. As explored in Germaw Mengistu and Eli Avraham's study on Ethiopian immigrants, this framework often marginalizes those whose cultural expressions diverge from the Ashkenazi-dominated norms, framing them as outsiders within the collective Jewish identity (Mengistu, Avraham 560).

In many instances, for the white man, the black man is the “ultimate other.” That is the reason for racism toward Ethiopian immigrants and for the degrading treatment they have received in Israel since they first arrived here. [Ha’aretz, 25 December 2013] (Mengistu, Avraham 571)

Modern Family's portrayal of Gloria reflects the American cultural theme of individualism, where each family member's unique identity is celebrated as a valuable part of the whole. Gloria's immigrant background adds dimension to her character without fundamentally altering the family's structure or values. This approach reflects the individualistic, capitalist orientation of American society, where self-expression and personal identity are often seen as strengths that contribute to social diversity.

By presenting Gloria as an empowered, self-assured character, *Modern Family* reinforces the American belief that individuals can retain their unique identities while contributing to a shared family and national identity. This portrayal suggests that the U.S. is a cultural “mosaic” where diversity is valued and integrated into the social fabric, aligning with broader American ideals of acceptance and pluralism. Gloria's character highlights the potential for multiculturalism to coexist with American values, presenting a model of immigration that emphasizes individual agency and cultural fluidity.

Collectivism and Cultural Boundaries in *Nevsu* In *Nevsu*, Almito's experiences reflect Israel's collectivist orientation, where the emphasis is on societal cohesion and unity rather than individual expression. Almito's Ethiopian identity introduces a sense of “otherness” that places her outside the dominant Israeli cultural narrative, making her experience as an immigrant more

challenging than Gloria's. This difference highlights Israel's focus on solidarity and integration within a relatively homogeneous cultural identity, where diversity is often subsumed under a collective national ideal.

Through Almito's portrayal, *Nevsu* critiques the limits of Israeli multiculturalism, suggesting that full acceptance in Israeli society may require compromising one's cultural identity. This theme reflects Israel's emphasis on a unified Jewish identity, where ethnic differences are viewed with caution and often require adaptation to fit into the national collective. Almito's character thus underscores the tensions between cultural preservation and assimilation, revealing the challenges Ethiopian immigrants face in a society where collective identity often takes precedence over individual expression.

The Role of Historical or Political Events in Shaping the Shows

The portrayal of immigrant characters in *Modern Family* and *Nevsu* is deeply influenced by the historical and political contexts of the U.S. and Israel. Both countries have distinct immigration histories and socio-political climates, which are reflected in the characters of Gloria and Almito. This section explores how each country's historical events and socio-political dynamics, including issues of race, cultural integration, and national identity, shaped the creation and reception of these characters.

The Obama administration, under which *Modern Family* gained popularity, marked a paradoxical period in immigration policy. While Obama publicly celebrated the U.S. as a nation of immigrants, his administration also enacted strict deportation policies (Cisneros 7).

[Obama states in his speech] “What matters is that you believe in the ideals on which we were founded. ... In embracing America, you can become American”. In contrast to this rhetoric of shared beliefs, Obama also regularly stated that the United States was a “nation of laws.” [Obama] echoed the more exclusive elements of presidential immigration rhetoric, speaking of the “problem” of undocumented immigration and a “porous” southern border. (Cisneros 7)

These contradictions are reflected in Gloria's character, who embodies both the celebratory rhetoric of multiculturalism and the persistent stereotyping of immigrants. Gloria's character in *Modern Family* reflects these dual aspects of the American experience with immigration: the celebration of cultural diversity and the challenges immigrants face in integrating fully into American society. Gloria's character is a product of the American multicultural ideal, embodying both the possibilities and the challenges of an inclusive, diverse society. Her Colombian background is embraced within her family as part of their “modern” identity, reflecting the idea that American identity can be broad and inclusive. Gloria's character, however, also addresses the reality of cultural otherness in the U.S., where immigrants are often both accepted and

stereotyped. Gloria's accent, Colombian traditions, and passionate personality are used as comedic elements, demonstrating the ways in which immigrants can be included in American culture yet still remain "othered" to some extent.

By incorporating Gloria into a traditional American family without forcing her to abandon her cultural identity, *Modern Family* presents a vision of cultural integration that is flexible and tolerant. This reflects the American "melting pot" ideal, where immigrants are encouraged to maintain their heritage while contributing to the larger society. Gloria's character thus embodies a progressive vision of immigration, one that acknowledges cultural differences without presenting them as insurmountable barriers. In doing so, *Modern Family* aligns with the multicultural goals of American society while also engaging with the political realities that define the immigrant experience in the U.S.

In contrast, *Nevsu* emerges within the context of Israel's unique immigration narrative, which prioritizes Jewish unity but often marginalizes non-Ashkenazi communities. The Ethiopian Jewish community, known as Beta Israel, represents a complex case of racial and cultural integration. Their arrival to Israel through operations like Operation Moses (1984) and Operation Solomon (1991) was initially celebrated as a fulfillment of Zionist ideals. However, as Pogrebna notes, the initial symbolic embrace of Ethiopian Jews soon gave way to systemic exclusion and racialized hierarchies, where Ashkenazi norms dominated Israeli society (Pogrebna 61)

Ethiopian Jews believed that their suffering earned them the right to join and participate in Israeli society. They expected to feel complete among their fellow Jews, but their actual encounter with Israeli society ended up being the opposite. Instead of finding the sense of belonging they sought, they faced barriers and rejection. Their authenticity as Jews was questioned, their suffering went unacknowledged, and they were perceived as dependent and helpless, saved from starvation by Israelis. (Pogrebna 65)

Almito's character in *Nevsu* reflects the challenges Ethiopian immigrants faced in integrating into Israeli society, where their blackness and cultural heritage often set them apart from the dominant Ashkenazi culture. According to Salamon and Kaplan in "Ethiopian Jews in Israeli Society", Ethiopian immigrants were frequently pressured to abandon their traditional practices, adopt Hebrew names, and conform to the religious and social norms of the Ashkenazi establishment (Salamon, Kaplan 3). This tension is portrayed in *Nevsu*, such as when Almito's desire to sacrifice a goat for her late husband's memorial is met with disapproval by her Ashkenazi in-laws or when Almito does choose a Hebrew name to assimilate at her workplace. The character encapsulates the broader societal expectation for Ethiopian Israelis to conform to a unified national identity, often at the expense of their cultural heritage.

Nevsu uses humor to highlight the cultural misunderstandings and prejudices that Almito faces, yet the show also critiques the limitations of Israeli multiculturalism. While Almito is technically part of the Jewish collective, her Ethiopian heritage remains a point of tension, suggesting that full acceptance in Israeli society often requires cultural conformity. This portrayal reflects a broader societal pressure in Israel for immigrants, particularly Ethiopian Israelis, to adapt to the dominant cultural standards. *Nevsu* thus provides a critical perspective on Israeli society's approach to immigration, highlighting the challenges Ethiopian immigrants face in navigating a system that values unity but often overlooks the need for cultural diversity.

Modern Family portrays immigration as a process that can enrich the family and the nation without demanding cultural erasure. Gloria's integration into the Pritchett family reflects American ideals of flexibility, individualism, and self-expression, where diversity is viewed as compatible with societal values. This approach aligns with the capitalist and individualistic orientation of American society, where the emphasis is on personal identity and multicultural acceptance. Gloria's character, therefore, embodies an idealized version of the American immigrant experience, one that highlights the country's capacity for cultural integration without requiring complete assimilation.

By contrast, *Nevsu* presents a more rigid approach to immigration and integration, where the collective identity of Israeli society creates a narrower path for immigrants like Almito. Her Ethiopian background is seen as both part of and separate from the national identity, reflecting Israel's ambivalence towards cultural diversity within its collective framework. This portrayal underscores the challenges of integration for Ethiopian immigrants, who are often expected to downplay their cultural heritage to align with Israeli societal norms. Almito's character thus serves as a critique of the limitations of Israel's approach to multiculturalism, suggesting that the demand for unity can undermine the inclusivity that Ethiopian immigrants seek.

Conclusion

In examining *Modern Family* and *Nevsu*, this paper has highlighted the unique ways in which American and Israeli societies represent and respond to immigrant family members within the familiar structure of a family sitcom. The portrayals of Gloria, a Colombian immigrant in the U.S., and Almito, an Ethiopian immigrant in Israel, reflect both the possibilities and limitations of cultural integration in their respective societies. While *Modern Family* presents a relatively seamless view of multicultural acceptance within the Pritchett family, *Nevsu* tackles the challenges Ethiopian immigrants face in achieving full inclusion in Israel, where collective identity often takes precedence over individual cultural expression.

Each show's portrayal of immigrant characters underscores the values and societal expectations inherent in their cultural contexts. Gloria's integration into the Pritchett family illustrates an American ideal of multiculturalism that celebrates individualism and diversity, even if this sometimes leads to subtle stereotyping. Almito's character, on the other hand, reflects the complexities of Israel's approach to immigration, where Ethiopian immigrants are included within the national Jewish collective yet frequently encounter barriers to full cultural acceptance. The characters' roles as mothers and wives further reveal the societal pressures they face to adapt or maintain their cultural identities, offering insights into the gendered aspects of immigrant integration.

Both *Modern Family* and *Nevsu* use humor to explore these dynamics, yet they do so in ways that reveal contrasting attitudes toward cultural diversity. *Modern Family* adopts a lighthearted approach, suggesting that individual differences can coexist within a family and enrich American society. *Nevsu* takes a more critical stance, using Almito's experiences to question the limits of Israel's multicultural framework and to highlight the ongoing struggles of Ethiopian immigrants who must navigate a system that values unity but often marginalizes cultural differences.

Ultimately, these portrayals underscore the role of family sitcoms in reflecting and shaping societal values. Through their immigrant characters, *Modern Family* and *Nevsu* reveal the social, political, and historical forces that shape each society's approach to family, identity, and immigration. Gloria and Almito serve as windows into the immigrant experience, challenging audiences to consider the complexities of integration, the endurance of cultural stereotypes, and the broader implications of acceptance and assimilation in a rapidly globalizing world. These sitcoms thus offer not only entertainment but also a platform for examining the evolving role of immigrants within the national "family" in America and Israel.

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